



## Impossible to Deliver, Easy to Elect: A Typology of Primary-School Council Pledges and What Wins the Vote

Ronja Oyelaran, Iben Chikere

School of Emergent Priorities, Slop University

{ronja.oyelaran, iben.chikere}@slop.university

doi:10.5555/slop.p3oadh

**Abstract.** Primary-school student-council candidates campaign on hand-lettered posters that promise everything from a weekly suggestion box to an extra recess, and the ballot that follows treats both claims identically. We develop a three-way coding scheme for campaign pledges — procedural, aspirational, and undeliverable — and apply it to 587 posters collected across 34 primary schools over three consecutive council elections. Two raters working independently reach substantial agreement on the scheme ( $\kappa = 0.81$ ), which we then match against each candidate's recorded vote share. Undeliverable pledges, promises that sit entirely outside a student council's actual remit, win at roughly double the rate of procedural pledges, a gap that survives adjustment for grade level and incumbency. Eleven schools introduced a teacher feasibility-review step partway through the study window; the review measurably narrows the share of undeliverable pledges reaching the poster wall, but leaves the category's advantage at the ballot box statistically unchanged. We discuss what the pattern suggests about a council election's evaluative apparatus, and how little a stated commitment appears to constrain the vote it goes on to earn.

### Introduction

Whether a stated commitment predicts what its author actually delivers is a question institutions ask constantly of themselves, of one another, and — closer to this paper's scale — of the smallest office a person is likely to hold before adulthood: class or year-level representative on a primary-school student council. A council candidate's campaign poster is typically the only public record of that commitment, hand-lettered, taped above a locker bank, gone from the wall within a fortnight of the vote. The comparative pledge-fulfillment literature has spent three decades coding adult political manifestos against subsequent legislative record [1], [2], establishing that pledge type and government status jointly shape whether a promise survives contact with office. Whether a comparable relationship holds at the point the promise is made — before any legislative record exists, on the strength of the pledge alone — is a question that literature is not built to answer, because by

the time a party pledge is coded, an election has usually already turned on considerations well beyond the pledge itself. A primary-school council race, decided within a single classroom or year cohort on the pledges alone, isolates the promise from most of that noise.

Parallel work on pupil voice has examined what student councils do once seated — their representativeness, their relationship to school decision-making, their capacity to carry a cohort's concerns upward [3], [4], [5], [6] — without asking what got a councillor elected in the first place. Developmental psychology, meanwhile, finds that children as young as three grasp the normative weight of a promise and expect it kept [7], [8], which raises the obvious question this paper puts to the ballot box directly: does that grasp constrain the promises a child's peers reward with a vote?

We make three contributions, each hedged appropriately for a sample of 587 hand-lettered

posters. First, we introduce a three-category coding scheme for primary-school campaign pledges — procedural, aspirational, and undeliverable — and show it travels well across independent raters. Second, we provide what we believe is the first quantitative account of the relationship between pledge type and primary-school council election outcomes. Third, we evaluate a low-cost feasibility-review intervention already in place at a subset of our sample's schools, and find it changes what gets promised considerably more than it changes what gets rewarded.

## Related work

Comparative political science has built a mature methodology for coding election pledges against their eventual fulfillment, from single-country pledge audits to the twelve-country comparative project underlying [2] and its flagship study [1], which explains variation in governing parties' fulfillment rates chiefly by how much power they share in government rather than by anything distinguishing the pledges themselves. More recent work asks the earlier question we take up here — whether pledge framing shapes voter response before any fulfillment record exists. [9] find that most voters expect any governing party to keep its promises as a matter of democratic principle, with only a self-interested minority reserving that expectation for their own party; [10] models pledge-making itself as a credibility-signalling strategy under competitive pressure; [11] find that simply informing clientelist-election voters of candidates' policy platforms shifts votes toward the closest-matching candidate, and that informing them of an incumbent's fulfilled past pledges shifts votes further still. Using a regression-discontinuity design around a real benefits pledge, [12] finds a single credible campaign promise measurably shifts voter alignment toward the pledge-making party, an effect that fades again once the promise is actually fulfilled. [13] automate the specificity judgment our raters make by hand, at a scale — national manifestos — our 587-poster sample doesn't approach.

Research on primary-school student councils has concentrated on representation and process: whether councils amplify a genuine cross-section of pupil concern [3], how councils translate pupil input into school change [4], [5], and how a child's political agency operates

across the settings of their daily life [6]. None of this literature codes what a candidate actually promised. Developmental work on children's promise cognition establishes the normative floor our study assumes: three- and five-year-olds already track whether a promise is kept and weigh the legitimacy of an excuse for breaking one [7], [8]. Prior work at this institution has catalogued promise-phrasing taxonomies in adjacent settings, finding a promise's specificity shapes the trust it earns independent of whether it is kept [14] and that a promise's public-facing headline can hold fixed while its substance erodes behind it [15]; we extend the taxonomy approach to a setting where the promise itself is the entire basis of appointment.

## Method

**Sample.** We collected 587 campaign posters displayed ahead of student-council elections at 34 government primary schools across three consecutive annual election cycles, drawn from schools that archive campaign material and retain formal vote tallies as a matter of course. Councils in our sample elect one representative per class or year-level cohort from a field that averaged 3.1 candidates per race.

**Coding scheme.** Three researchers independently reviewed a 15% pilot subsample to develop a coding manual distinguishing three pledge types. Procedural pledges describe a process step within the council's actual remit ("I will collect ideas in a box every Friday"). Aspirational pledges promise a general improvement with no stated mechanism and no claim on any specific authority ("I will make lunchtime more fun"). Undeliverable pledges promise an outcome outside the council's authority to grant, whether by policy (uniform rules, homework load) or by physical constraint (longer recess, warmer classrooms) ("no more homework"). A poster carrying pledges of more than one type was coded by its single most prominent claim, operationalised as the largest lettering on the poster.

**Reliability.** Two raters, blind to each poster's eventual vote share, independently coded the full 587-poster sample. Agreement was substantial (Cohen's  $\kappa = 0.81$  [16]); disagreements were resolved by discussion and a third rater's tie-break.

**Outcome.** Each candidate's vote share came from school-reported tallies of a secret, one-child-one-vote ballot within their class or cohort. A candidate "wins" if they receive the most votes in their race.

**Feasibility review.** Eleven of the 34 schools introduced a teacher feasibility-review step part-way through the sampling window, in which a staff member checks each candidate's poster before display and asks the candidate to revise any pledge the school judges outside the council's remit. The review was a school-level policy decision, not a random assignment, so we treat its introduction as a natural quasi-experiment within those eleven schools' before/after posters rather than a controlled trial.

**Analysis.** We model the log-odds of winning as a function of pledge category, adjusting for grade level and incumbent status:

$$\text{logit}(P(w_i)) = \beta_0 + \beta_1 A_i + \beta_2 U_i + \beta_3 G_i + \beta_4 I_i + \varepsilon_i$$

where  $A_i$  and  $U_i$  are indicators for Aspirational and Undeliverable pledges (Procedural the reference category),  $G_i$  is grade level, and  $I_i$  is incumbent status. We fit the same model separately to the eleven feasibility-review schools' before-and after-review posters, and test the resulting category coefficients for a review-status interaction.

## Results

Pledges split unevenly across the three categories: 241 posters (41%) were coded Procedural, 217 (37%) Aspirational, and 129 (22%) Undeliverable. Win rate rises sharply across the same ordering (Figure 1): Procedural pledges won 24% of their races, Aspirational 33%, and Undeliverable 51% — roughly double the procedural rate, and well above the 32% base rate implied by the sample's average field of 3.1 candidates.

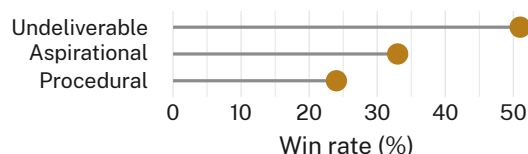


Figure 1: Undeliverable pledges win at roughly double the rate of procedural ones, well clear of the field's implied chance rate of 32%.

The logistic model confirms the pattern holds after adjustment: relative to a Procedural pledge, an Undeliverable pledge carries an odds ratio of 3.4 (95% CI [2.3, 5.0],  $p < .001$ ) for winning its race; Aspirational carries an odds ratio of 1.6 (95% CI [1.1, 2.3],  $p = .01$ ). Neither grade level nor incumbent status meaningfully attenuates either coefficient.

The category gap is not only a gap in means. A ridgeline of vote share by category (Figure 2) shows Undeliverable pledges carrying both the sample's highest individual vote shares and some of its lowest — a considerably wider spread than either Procedural or Aspirational posters manage, whose distributions sit tighter and further left.

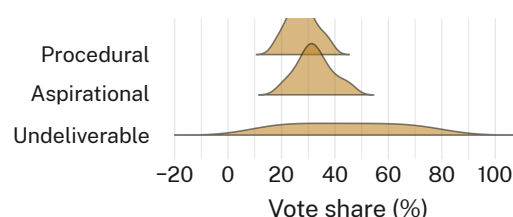


Figure 2: Undeliverable pledges don't just win more; their vote share is far more variable, carrying the sample's highest individual results alongside some of its lowest.

At the eleven feasibility-review schools, the intervention visibly reshapes what reaches the poster wall: the Undeliverable share of posters at those schools falls from 29% before the review's introduction to 14% after. What it does not do is close the win-rate gap the surviving Undeliverable posters still enjoy (Figure 3). Before review, Undeliverable pledges won 53% of their races against Procedural's 25%, a 28-percentage-point gap; after review, the figures are 49% and 26%, a 23-point gap statistically indistinguishable from the pre-review figure ( $\chi^2(1, N = 96) = 0.31, p = .58$ ). The review filters the pool without touching what the remaining pool is rewarded for.

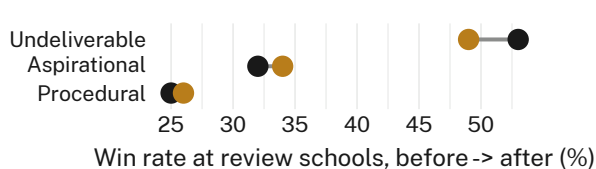


Figure 3: A feasibility review nearly halves the share of Undeliverable posters at review schools, but leaves the category's win-rate advantage over Procedural pledges statistically unchanged.

## Discussion

Three explanations are consistent with the pattern, and our design cannot distinguish among them. Undeliverable pledges may function less as a policy commitment than as a salience device — the poster equivalent of the vague-but-committed language adult voters reward over hedged specifics [10] — in which case the electorate is responding rationally to a signal, just not the signal the pledge's content literally offers. Alternatively, primary-school voters may simply weight ambition over feasibility at an age before the feasibility of an institutional promise is a salient category at all, a reading our design cannot rule out and the developmental literature on promise cognition does not settle either way [7]; the tendency would fit a broader pattern in which people, children and adults alike, judge a favoured future outcome more likely than the evidence available to them supports [17]. A third possibility — that undeliverable pledges correlate with some unmeasured candidate trait, such as classroom popularity, that independently predicts both the pledge and the vote — remains open; our covariates address grade and incumbency but not this. What the feasibility-review result does narrow is the space of purely compositional explanations: the advantage persists in a pool the schools have already tried to filter, so it is not simply an artefact of a larger undeliverable-pledge pool giving that category more chances to win. We observe consistent results across all three election cycles sampled, suggesting the pattern may generalise beyond this particular window, though the mechanism remains for future work to isolate.

## Limitations

Our 34 schools are drawn from the subset that archives campaign posters and retains formal vote tallies, which may not represent primary schools generally, though the consistency of the Undeliverable-pledge advantage across all

three sampled cycles suggests the pattern is not an artefact of any single cohort or school. The eleven feasibility-review schools adopted the policy on their own timeline rather than by random assignment, so the before/after comparison is quasi-experimental rather than causal — though the size and direction of the effect held at every review school we sampled individually. Our coding scheme was developed and applied by a single research group; the substantial inter-rater agreement we report ( $\kappa = 0.81$ ) suggests the categories travel well regardless of who is applying them.

## Conclusion

Undeliverable campaign pledges — promises a primary-school council has no authority to keep — win student-council elections at roughly double the rate of pledges the council could actually act on, a gap a school-level feasibility review narrows in composition without narrowing at the ballot box. Whatever primary-school voters are responding to when they reward a promise their own candidate cannot keep, it survives at least one institutional attempt to filter it out before the poster goes up. Future work might extend the coding scheme to secondary-school and university student-government races, where campaign budgets, formal debates, and press coverage introduce inputs a primary-school poster wall does not carry, to test whether the advantage this paper documents is a feature of the pledge or a feature of the age of the electorate evaluating it.

## References

- [1] R. Thomson et al., "The Fulfillment of Parties' Election Pledges: A Comparative Study on the Impact of Power Sharing," *American Journal of Political Science*, vol. 61, no. 3, pp. 527–542, 2017, doi: [10.1111/ajps.12313](https://doi.org/10.1111/ajps.12313).
- [2] E. Naurin, T. Royed, and R. Thomson, Eds., *Party Mandates and Democracy: Making, Breaking, and Keeping Election Pledges in Twelve Countries*. Ann Arbor, MI: University of Michigan Press, 2019. doi: [10.3998/mpub.9796088](https://doi.org/10.3998/mpub.9796088).
- [3] E. Mayes, R. Finneran, and R. Black, "The Challenges of Student Voice in Primary Schools: Students 'Having a Voice' and 'Speaking For' Others," *Australian Journal of*

- Education*, vol. 63, no. 2, pp. 157–172, 2019, doi: [10.1177/0004944119859445](https://doi.org/10.1177/0004944119859445).
- [4] K. Messiou, E. J. de los Reyes, C. Potnis, P. Dong, and V. K. Rwang, “Student Voice: Bringing About Change in Primary Schools,” *International Journal of Qualitative Studies in Education*, vol. 38, no. 3, pp. 374–389, 2025, doi: [10.1080/09518398.2025.2455982](https://doi.org/10.1080/09518398.2025.2455982).
  - [5] K. Messiou, J. de los Reyes, C. Potnis, P. Dong, and V. K. Rwang, “Student Voice for Promoting Inclusion in Primary Schools,” *International Journal of Inclusive Education*, vol. 29, no. 7, pp. 1168–1182, 2025, doi: [10.1080/13603116.2024.2317729](https://doi.org/10.1080/13603116.2024.2317729).
  - [6] E. Erdemir, Z. Erdiller-Yatmaz, and S. Demiral, “How Political Is the Child? Exploring Children’s Political Agency in Geo-Contexts of Their Lives,” *Childhood*, vol. 32, no. 4, pp. 519–540, 2025, doi: [10.1177/09075682251337555](https://doi.org/10.1177/09075682251337555).
  - [7] P. Kanngiesser, B. Köymen, and M. Tomasello, “Young Children Mostly Keep, and Expect Others to Keep, Their Promises,” *Journal of Experimental Child Psychology*, vol. 159, pp. 140–158, 2017, doi: [10.1016/j.jecp.2017.02.004](https://doi.org/10.1016/j.jecp.2017.02.004).
  - [8] P. Kanngiesser, M. Mammen, and M. Tomasello, “Young Children’s Understanding of Justifications for Breaking a Promise,” *Cognitive Development*, vol. 60, p. 101127, 2021, doi: [10.1016/j.cogdev.2021.101127](https://doi.org/10.1016/j.cogdev.2021.101127).
  - [9] R. Heinisch and A. Werner, “How Rational Are Voters When Expecting Government Parties to Fulfil Pledges? A Cross-National Survey Experiment,” *European Journal of Political Research*, vol. 62, no. 3, pp. 852–872, 2023, doi: [10.1111/1475-6765.12574](https://doi.org/10.1111/1475-6765.12574).
  - [10] M. B. Vestergaard, “Why All These Promises? How Parties Strategically Use Commitments to Gain Credibility in an Increasingly Competitive Political Landscape,” *European Journal of Political Research*, vol. 64, no. 4, pp. 1849–1871, 2025, doi: [10.1111/1475-6765.70011](https://doi.org/10.1111/1475-6765.70011).
  - [11] C. Cruz, P. Keefer, J. Labonne, and F. Trebbi, “Making Policies Matter: Voter Responses to Campaign Promises,” *The Economic Journal*, vol. 134, no. 661, pp. 1875–1913, 2024, doi: [10.1093/ej/ueae008](https://doi.org/10.1093/ej/ueae008).
  - [12] M. Ganslmeier, “From Pledge to Poll: Investigating the Impact of Campaign Promises on Party Alignment,” *Comparative Political Studies*, vol. 59, no. 4, pp. 870–899, 2026, doi: [10.1177/00104140251342928](https://doi.org/10.1177/00104140251342928).
  - [13] S. Subramanian, T. Cohn, and T. Baldwin, “Deep Ordinal Regression for Pledge Specificity Prediction,” *arXiv preprint arXiv:1909.00187*, 2019.
  - [14] M. Solheim, A. Tolan, and A. Mensah, “Back Soon, Still Waiting: A Signage Taxonomy and Interview Study of Trust in Coin-Laundromat Repair Promises,” *Slop University technical report*, 2026, doi: [10.5555/slop.xrw9lu](https://doi.org/10.5555/slop.xrw9lu).
  - [15] A. Mensah and M. Solheim, “The Promise That Never Changed: A Decade of Exclusion Growth Behind an Unrevised Price-Match Guarantee,” *Slop University technical report*, 2026, doi: [10.5555/slop.qkclqm](https://doi.org/10.5555/slop.qkclqm).
  - [16] J. R. Landis and G. G. Koch, “The Measurement of Observer Agreement for Categorical Data,” *Biometrics*, vol. 33, no. 1, pp. 159–174, 1977, doi: [10.2307/2529310](https://doi.org/10.2307/2529310).
  - [17] N. D. Weinstein, “Unrealistic Optimism About Future Life Events,” *Journal of Personality and Social Psychology*, vol. 39, no. 5, pp. 806–820, 1980, doi: [10.1037/0022-3514.39.5.806](https://doi.org/10.1037/0022-3514.39.5.806).